



GULF-BOUND KERALITES LINE UP AT A PASSPORT OFFICE

tampering can be detected with new machines like QDX or ultraviolet lamps. "After the recent installation of hi-tech QDX machines to detect counterfeit passports, seizures have increased. Since May, 42 cases have been detected," says an official.

Another method the racket employs is selling passports to those with similar faces as the original owner. "Since passports may be issued many years earlier with photos taken then, minor differences in faces are likely to be ignored. It is almost impossible to nail them," says a police official. The rackets get hold of original passports either by stealing or buying from poor migrants who are desperate for money.

Central minister for Overseas Indian Affairs Vayalar Ravi, who is

from Kerala, has said that it is the state Government's duty to curb fake passport rackets. But state police officials say that the investigation can't make much headway as the purchasers would know nothing more than the name of the tout. "This tout would bring the passports to the airport minutes before take-off," says Basheer Ali, a Keralite migrant working in Dubai.

After a passenger holding a fake passport is caught, he is handed over to the state police's crime branch for further investigation. "It is difficult to trace the racket without international collaboration as it has its roots in the Gulf," says an IG, Kerala Police.

The organised racket which forges travel documents and passports works with an active involvement of travel and recruiting agents and emigration officials at airports. Last year, the CBI had registered cases against Protectors of Emigrants Offices (POE) at Thiruvananthapuram, Chennai, Hyderabad, Mumbai and Chandigarh on charges of accepting bribes and forging of travel

ports are either those whose passports are in possession of their sponsors or those whose passports have been seized by the authorities after their involvement in criminal activities, says V.M. Sathish, a journalist in Dubai. "Sponsors and employers keep the employees' passports to prevent them from leaving or switching jobs. Stranded migrants desperate to get back home are easy prey," says K.V. Muraleedharan, president, Kerala Association of Travel Agents.

According to the Research Unit on International Migration at the Centre for Development Studies in Thiruvananthapuram, 55 per cent of the migrants were not allowed to keep their passports or work permits by their employers or sponsors. "It is a fundamental right of the workers to keep their passports. The prevailing practice of employers confiscating them is against international law and violates fundamental human rights," says S. Irudayarajan, head of research.

The study has also revealed various

“ This racket has been in operation since the '80s and is rooted in the Gulf, though most organisers and users are from Kerala. ”

K. PADMA KUMAR, IG (Intelligence), Kerala Police



documents, passports and visas. Following the raid in the POE offices in Thiruvananthapuram where hundreds of forged visas were confiscated, 17 travel agents were arrested. In July last year Jagadananda Panda, protector-general of emigrants at Delhi had committed suicide after shooting down four of his family members under mysterious conditions.

Koya suspects his passport details were passed on by a travel agency. His inquiries have revealed that Samad had purchased tickets from the same agency in Dubai which had arranged for Koya's tickets in December 2009. "I had submitted my passport to the agency. I don't know if the details were leaked from there," he says.

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ports are either those whose passports are in possession of their sponsors or those whose passports have been seized by the authorities after their involvement in criminal activities, says V.M. Sathish, a journalist in Dubai. "Sponsors and employers keep the employees' passports to prevent them from leaving or switching jobs. Stranded migrants desperate to get back home are easy prey," says K.V. Muraleedharan, president, Kerala Association of Travel Agents.

Now, the Kasargod Embassy has become a bane for the poor families of 10 persons who died in the Mangalore crash. For they have not only lost their breadwinners but also the hope of receiving a decent compensation. ■